2.2 The Boston Massacre

If you place a flame too close to a powder keg full of explosive gunpowder, it will blow up spectacularly. In 1770, Boston was like a powder keg, and a hot flame was quickly approaching.

MAIN IDEA Tensions between the British troops and the colonists in Boston reached a breaking point when some soldiers fired on an angry crowd of citizens.

TENSIONS RISE

In response to growing protests and increasing unrest among colonists, British authorities brought additional troops to Boston. Some of the soldiers camped out on Boston Common, an open area that was intended for all Bostonians to use.

This arrangement made for a tense situation. Frequent fights broke out between soldiers and civilians. To annoy the British soldiers, children followed them in the streets, taunting them and calling them names such as "redcoats" and "lobsterbacks" because of the bright red uniforms they wore.

In addition, the British soldiers were poorly paid. To make extra money, they took jobs as workers during their off-duty hours. This took jobs away from some Bostonians, who were angry at losing work to soldiers they already despised.

On March 5, 1770, a boy began yelling insults at a British soldier standing guard at a government building. The soldier hit the boy with his gun. A rowdy crowd gathered around the commotion, and Captain Thomas Preston led a group of seven additional soldiers out to diffuse the situation. The crowd grew larger, throwing snowballs, ice, and sticks at the soldiers. Then someone hit a soldier with a club, knocking his gun out of his hands.

TENSIONS EXPLODE

Suddenly Preston's men were firing at the crowd. Five townspeople were killed and six were injured. This event soon became known as the **Boston Massacre**. To the colonists, the killings would come to symbolize all that they hated about British rule.

The first man shot and killed was **Crispus Attucks**, an African American and former slave who worked as a sailor and rope maker in Boston. Attucks is considered to be the first person to die in the quest for American independence.

After the shooting, the soldiers were arrested and put on trial for murder. At the trial, they were represented by lawyer **John Adams**, a cousin of Samuel Adams. This surprised some people because John Adams was a well-known Patriot, or supporter of colonial self-rule, in addition to being a respected lawyer. But he was also a firm believer in the right to a fair trial for everyone, no matter how unpopular they were.

Adams claimed that the soldiers had fired in self-defense. He made his case so eloquently that Captain Preston and all but two of the soldiers were found not guilty. Many people, including John Adams, thought this trial would be the end of his legal career. Yet in the end, Bostonians came to respect Adams for making the unpopular but ethical choice. He went on to have a distinguished career in politics, including serving as the first vice president and second president of the United States.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What events led up to the Boston Massacre?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** What was the general feeling in Boston in 1770?
3. **ANALYZE VISUALS** What similarities and differences can you identify in the two depictions of the Boston Massacre at right?

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The Bloody Massacre

American Patriot Paul Revere wasn't the first person to use a tragic incident to sway people's opinions, but he did it particularly effectively in the engraved print on the left. Titled *The Bloody Massacre in King Street*, the print shows a line of British soldiers firing into an unarmed crowd when, in fact, violence erupted on both sides. If you look closely at the white building on the right—the Customs House—you can also see that Revere changed its name to "Butcher's Hall." You may also notice that Crispus Attucks isn't represented in the print.

In fact, Attucks wouldn't be portrayed as a person of color until artist William L. Champney depicted him at the event in his 1855 drawing *Boston Massacre*. The antislavery movement was at its height, so the artist placed Attucks squarely in the center of the action. He also shows the colonists taking a more active role in the fight—probably a more accurate depiction of the incident.



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